Honecker explored two parallel lines of movement: a so-called faction aimed at deposing Ulbricht and incompetence. When he had amassed enough ‘evidence’, Honecker charged that Wollweber’s ‘false appraisal’ of 17 June prevented state security agencies from performing their duties properly:

The struggle against subversive elements was criminally neglected by Comrade Wollweber. Investigations showed that he had failed in his duties. Instead, he tried to recruit other comrades for the divisive work of the Schirdewan group. This divisive activity was conducted with a lot of talk. Oppositional agencies were able to acquire information about internal party matters and use it against the party.

4

As for Schirdewan, Honecker barked that his deviation from the Party line became clear during the Hungarian revolt. Furthermore, he allegedly ‘underestimated the dangers of NATO policy and ignored attempts by West German militarists to undermine the GDR’.5 During this dressing down, Schirdewan glimpsed the glint of cold steel behind Honecker’s affable façade: ‘It was like an inquisition from the Middle Ages.’ Fred Oelssner, chief party theoretician, was also expelled from the Politburo. Heinz Brandt, an SED functionary in Berlin, described the loss of Schirdewan as a bitter blow to reformers. ‘When Khrushchev got into increasing difficulties after the Hungary debacle – after all, he was accused of having triggered the signs of disintegration in the hitherto ‘monolithic’ Eastern bloc with his secret speech and his thaw policy – he saw himself forced to concede on the Schirdewan-Wollweber issue’.

Firmly back in the saddle,6 Walter Ulbricht issued a communique decrying the ‘activities of an opportunist group which attempted to change the party line’. For his sterling efforts, Erich Mielke – Wollweber’s aggressive